



The 10 Core Pillars of Transformational Parenting

Phase 1, Week 3: Please *complete* this workbook before this week's group call

The 10 Core Pillars of Transformational Parenting are what hold us in a secure foundation as we traverse the terrain of conscious, transformational parenting. There is no expectation, or requirement, for perfection here. Please be gentle and kind to yourself as you begin, or deepen, your relationship with these fundamentals.

Transformational Parenting is Power With Parenting.

We embody a core belief that everyone in the family is inherently equal, even if there is a distinct difference in maturity, brain development, neurodiversity, needs, and capability. Each person is inherently worthy of sovereignty, dignity, empowerment, and respect.

The “HEAD” of Transformational Parenting

This represents the willingness to utilize our access to scientific, and evidence-based research to support and affirm our longing to parent peacefully.

1. Informed and Aware

When practicing Transformation Parenting, we understand parenting takes skill building, constant learning, and a willingness to be informed of the latest research, science, and understanding of how children best develop and blossom. We are willing to challenge conditioned and outdated modes of thinking that place expectations and responsibility on children that are developmentally inappropriate, and sometimes harmful.

We embrace brain science, attachment science, nervous system science, emotional intelligence, and conscious communication. We take responsibility for ourselves, as the parent or caregiver, to understand what is happening beneath the behavior of the child.



We take responsibility for assuring our family rules, boundaries, and expectations fit with the current development of our child's brain, body, and being.

Alfie Kohn, author of *Unconditional Parenting*, urges us to "reconsider your requests." Are your expectations, requests, and demands appropriate for your child's age, development, temperament, and quality of attachment? A child's 'ability' to handle requests can change, often within the same day (or even the same hour!). Development isn't linear, and the adult understands that.

2. Intentional and Reflective

Slow Down!

We view this work as an utmost priority and slow down, declutter our lives, and carve out the necessary time to make daily intentions and reflections. We soften our resistance to how much energy and effort this commitment to transformational parenting requires. We stand in full self-responsibility, as the parent in the family, and reject blaming our children for our struggles and challenges in parenthood. We set daily intentions.

We reflect daily on what is working, what is not working, what needs to be tweaked, how our children can be served and cared for, and what we need as parents to thrive as leaders.

3. Present, Committed, and Devoted to Imperfect Authenticity

We are dedicated to continual self-growth. We live from a space of curiosity; when we react, we respond to our reaction with curiosity and a willingness to understand. We are aware that unprocessed feelings, experiences, and stressors from childhood can feel overwhelming and cloud our ability to be present in the moment with our child or children. We are willing to take full responsibility for how we feel, think, believe, and respond or react to our child's feelings, needs, requests, and behaviors.

We actively seek and practice receiving the support we need. We release the expectation of becoming a perfect parent, and instead commit ourselves to continuous growth, awareness, and accountability. We parent for the future well being of our child, not for immediate gratification or ease. These are not mutually exclusive, though our priority is the long term relationship.



The “HEART” of Transformational Parenting

This represents the emotional intelligence of peaceful parenting strategies and values.

4. All Feelings are Valid and Welcome

When practicing transformational parenting, we are actively engaged in our own emotional intelligence. We practice learning how to name our emotional reactivity, our feelings, and our needs. We understand that there are no “good” or “bad” feelings, for ourselves or our children, and we make space for all feelings to be felt. We model emotional containment by not reacting, to the best of our capacity, when overcome with strong emotion. We practice mindfulness of our feelings, acceptance, and non-judgment, so we can process our feelings, and allow them to pass.

5. Attuned and Empathetic

We are dedicated to attuning to our children’s experience. We are willing to practice wondering and exploring how our children may be feeling... what their experience may be. We are soft, warm, and willing to offer gentle, considerate responses to our child’s big feelings, disoriented actions, and mistakes.

We understand that we are responsible for our feelings and can separate how we feel from how our child feels. We are willing to look beneath any behavior as our child’s best attempt to meet their needs, communicate their experience, and cope with their big feelings. We are willing to practice self-empathy, increasing our awareness and acceptance of our own emotional experiences: our feelings, needs, thoughts, and beliefs.

6. Loving Kindness and Forgiveness

We are dedicated to noticing where we can soften our harshness into kindness, unconditional acceptance, and a willingness to forgive (ourselves and others).

We practice generous assumptions, and reject assuming our child makes choices intentionally, willingly, out of spite or manipulation, malice, or ill will. We are generously assuming our children are always doing the best they can: their behavior is communication, not manipulation. We see conflict and mistakes as opportunities to connect, learn, and grow. We remember that mistakes are a natural part of the process of growth and development.



The “HAND” of Transformational Parenting

This represents our understanding of the practical, evidence-based tools of peaceful parenting.

7. Communication to Connect and Understand

When practicing transformational parenting, we are dedicated to unlearning communication programming rooted in judgment, criticism, blame, shame, and projection. We are willing to learn and practice non-violent, compassionate communication within our own heads, and with our children. Alfie Kohn calls this **“talk less, ask more.”** We practice daily, taking ownership for our feelings and needs, and communicating directly, compassionately, and with curiosity. We will hold space for our children as they find their voice and we will make space for their voice to be heard.

8. Nonviolence and Safety

We make a commitment to non-violence in thought, word, and deed. We aim to keep our household a space of warmth, comfort, and peace. This includes utilizing communication, clear limits, empathetic support, and creative problem solving when we are in need of help in our parenting. We practice non-violence with ourselves through self-empathy, compassion, and forgiveness when we cross a boundary of safety and respect with our child. We are dedicated to reaching out for support when we realize we are depending on forceful and disrespectful parenting tactics.

9. Boundaries from Family Values

We are dedicated to setting limits, rules, and boundaries from the clarity of our core values. We are confident in knowing when to stand firm with our boundaries, and when it is safe and appropriate to soften into flexibility. We take responsibility as adults to support our children’s needs, whatever they may be, at any age, to meet those expectations and boundaries. If we are not willing to be an active and engaged participant of our boundary being honored, we are willing to get curious about how important that boundary truly is to us.

10. Joy, Play, and Fun!

We are dedicated to unearthing and celebrating the essence of parenting: raising children can be fun! We are dedicated to learning how to soften conflict through connective play. We embrace play as our children’s process for understanding, healing, and transforming stressed behavior into self-connected and cooperative behavior. We prioritize joy and laughter when stress and fatigue overwhelm the family culture.



Get Curious!

Reflect on the pillars above and what they mean to you, and how they manifest (or don't) in your family. No judgment here; just exploration.

- I. *Which pillar(s) come easily to you? For one or two of them, share an example of what this looks like in your family.*

- II. *Which pillar(s) are challenging for you? Are they challenging because:*

- *You don't know how to practice them*
- *You feel resistance*
- *You don't believe they are important*
- *They don't match your family values, or something else?*
- *Be compassionate with yourself in your explanation.*



Understanding the Parenting “Power Continuum”

Power Over, Under, and With dynamics occur in any intimate relationship. Often, these dynamics stem from a lack of self-awareness, tools, or support. It is very common and normal for you to identify with each of these power dynamics on any given day. It is not black or white, but gray.

Power Over Parenting (Authoritarian)

- There is minimal space for the child’s feelings, thoughts, needs, desires, wants, and voice. The parent is at the top of the hierarchy and the child is at the bottom.
- The child is to be “seen and not heard” and children must be trained how to “be good.”
- Parents make unilateral decisions without considering the child’s perspective, development, feelings, needs, or opinions. *“I am the parent and I know best!”*
- Parents must “rule with an iron fist” so their child does not turn out “spoiled and entitled.”
- In order to avoid vulnerability and protect their own internal sense of powerlessness, the parent’s physiological state moves to the “fight” response.
- Fear and shame is used as a tool to control children’s behavior, or the parent’s external environment. This includes: yelling, shaming, threatening, punitive time outs, name calling, any kind of physical harm, withholding food, isolation, and comparison.
- Demand obedience without any explanation is common. *“Don’t ask why, just do it!”*
- Children are punished, lectured, shamed, or criticized for their mistakes.
- Parents blame children for their own lack of emotional regulation.
- Parents retaliate against the child’s dysregulated and disoriented behavior.
- Parents act from fear without awareness or reflection.
- Parents want to control who their child is, how they feel, and how they act in order to be seen as a “good parent.”
- Love and acceptance are conditional on the child’s success, achievement, performance, or behavior.
- Parents see their child AS their behaviors, and focus on molding, sculpting, or correcting behaviors, rather than trying to understand the behaviors, meet the core need, accept the developmental stage, and model the skills the child will eventually grow into, on their own time, at their own pace.

Power Under Parenting

Permissive

- Parents struggle with being present, physically or emotionally, and children are expected to “raise themselves.”
- Parents may struggle to set grounded boundaries from clear values. The stress of needing to parent from a place of confidence and leadership can be too much to bear, so they prefer to keep quiet, stay passive, and allow their children to make their own decisions.
- May feel confused about what they value.
- Struggle using their voice and communicating their feelings and needs.
- May experience little support and choose very loose boundaries for the sake of temporary ease.
- Do not believe they are a competent teacher.
- May feel their child’s rejection or “no!” as emotional abandonment, so they avoid doing or saying anything that will upset their child.
- Fear of conflict may keep them quiet; they may believe they are incapable, powerless, or helpless.
- May have a very low self esteem, and spend much time in a physiological state of flight, freeze or shutdown.

Uninvolved

- This parent may be completely, or partially “checked out.”
- Not physically or emotionally available. (We recognize that this is not always a choice of the parent to not be present).
- This parent is devoid of warmth and nurturance and may appear “there but not really there.”
- Sees parenting as a burden to escape.

Power With Parenting

- We have access to, and are committed to developing, a sense of safety and security.
- We believe that children deserve to be treated with respect, kindness, and understanding.
- We are our child's first advocate. We are willing to stand up for our child when people in the public eye do not understand and want to punish the child for being a child.
- We commit and recommit to curiosity. Is willing to look beneath the surface of behaviors and understand the "why" behind the moment. We seek to understand child development. We are willing to look within when overwhelmed in the presence of the child, and understand the "why" beneath the parent's own impulse and behavior.
- We are committed to self-awareness, accountability, and attunement as one of the most important parenting tools.
- We ask for help when we need it and believe we are worthy of receiving support.
- We are willing to grow and heal our inner sense of self, so we can access confidence, clear leadership, and a positive state of mind.
- We commit to developing intuition, and listening to our own inner voice.
- We are willing to accept that we are the most developmentally mature member of the parent-child dyad, and are willing to model accommodation, adaptation, and meeting the needs of a person who cannot meet those needs on their own.
- We believe that kids are always doing their very best with what they can access at the moment. We believe that about ourselves, too.
- We embrace restorative justice (rebuilding the relationship after an offense), and seek to understand how to best navigate conflict as safely as possible, where everyone's needs, experience, and wants are honored.
- We choose the relationship first, and use skills and tools that respect the connection and the relationship.
- We let go of control, and step into vulnerability, humility, and radical trust. We love and accept who our child is unconditionally.
- We commit to emotional attunement and empathy. We hold space for our child's feelings and their voice.
- We commit to collaboration and believe that we will discover what works best for our unique family by committing to communication, exploration, patience, and discovery.
- We model self-accountability when harm is done to the child or the relationship.
- We seek joy, find humor, and celebrate the little moments with our children.



Gaining Compassion for Our Fears

What keeps parents from practicing Power With Parenting is often the result of living and parenting from fear. Fear is very real and very valid. And, we are here to understand our fears so we can show them curiosity and compassion. When we can understand what holds us back, we can work to soften those barriers and gain greater agency from a space of truth and trust.

- Fear of not belonging and judgment
- Fear for our children's safety in the bigger world
- Fear for our children's social success in the world
- Fear of "being out of control," powerlessness
- Fear of "coddling"
- Fear of inadequacy
- Fear of "failure"
- Other? _____

III. *Which of these fears (if any) are most alive in your parenting?*

IV. *What fear keeps you from practicing Power With Parenting?*



- V. *If you could offer your fear compassion, what would you say to your fear? What does your fear need to feel safe?*

(Ex: Dear fear, it makes sense why you feel that way! You want what's best for your child, and there is so much that is unknown. How can I support you to trust?)



Generational Parenting Patterns

We will begin by exploring the power dynamics of your family of origin. The intention is to support you to have greater coherence and context for your current parenting pattern.

Childhood Parenting Pattern

- VI. *Drawing from the information above, what Power Pattern was most consistently alive in your childhood home?*

- VII. *If you had two caregivers in your home growing up, did they exercise a similar, or inconsistent parenting pattern?*

- VIII. *If you were raised with the Power Over or Under pattern, can you recall a specific event that stands out in your childhood where this dynamic was at play?*

- IX. *Recalling this Power Over or Under scenario now, how do you feel? This isn't what you think about it; it's how the memory feels in your body.*



- X. *What did you think about yourself because of experiencing this kind of behavior from your parents or caregiver?*

- XI. *How has this thought about yourself remained present in your life? Has it shown up in other ways?*

- XII. *If you could talk with this thought, what would you say? Write a message to this thought with compassion and non-judgment.*

- XIII. *If you could travel back in time and put yourself in your parent or caregiver's shoes, what do you think that they were feeling at that time that they displayed some behavior that led to disconnected communication?*

(Ex: yelling, punishing, hitting, shaming, blaming, manipulating, neglecting, ignoring, etc.)



Your Current Parenting Pattern

- XIV. *Drawing from the information above, what parenting pattern beliefs and strategies are most consistently alive in your parenting and in your home?*

- XV. *If you are partnered, do you have a similar parenting style, or is there inconsistency?*

- XVI. *Recall a time, or several, in your parenting, where you were able to access one or more Transformational Parenting Pillars.*

- XVII. *Recalling these memories, how do you feel?*

- XVIII. *When you were parenting from the Power With dynamic, how do you imagine your child felt? What kinds of thoughts about themselves and the world do you imagine they were having during this experience?*



XIX. *Recall a time, or several, where you found yourself slipping into the Power Over or Under pattern? (Remember, there is no judgment here. Often, these behaviors are left over from our own childhoods. You are in the right and perfect place!)*

XX. *Recalling this scenario, how were you feeling when you slipped into Power Over or Under parenting?*

XXI. *What support were you needing when you slipped into Power Over or Under parenting?*

XXII. *What kinds of thoughts were running through your mind when you slipped into Power Over or Under parenting?*

XXIII. *We invite you to pause here and offer yourself grace and kindness. What kind and loving words can you offer yourself at this moment?*



Your Child or Children

- XXIV. *What commitment can you make to yourself right now that will soften the cycle of Power Over or Under parenting patterns by disrupting the repetition of them?*

- XXV. *If you could write a letter to your future generations, your great-great-great-great grandchildren, what do you want them to know? What do you want them to feel? What do you want them to experience in their childhoods? Their lives?*



Moving From Control To Connection: What Keeps Us Stuck In Behaviorism

What sets Transformational Parenting apart from any paradigm of the past, is our dedication to see our children beneath their behaviors, and into their deeper internal social-emotional and neurological development.

We are eliminating, slowly and surely, the need for threats, bribes, punishments, withdrawal of love and connection, praise and rewards. Instead of hyper focusing solely on what the child is or is not doing, we ask ourselves: What is happening deep within my child that is creating this symptom?

We are not here to change parents' behaviors, nor are we here to change our children's behaviors! Challenging behaviors will inevitably shift, but not from the parent's sheer willpower and the child's desire to "be good." This shift happens when the child experiences inner safety and when the parent integrates and embodies tools like communication, emotional intelligence, and relational safety.

We are here to look beneath the surface and ask ourselves how can I, as the parent, be with myself more compassionately and wholly so I do not need a coping mechanism like yelling, punishing, or shutting down?

We ask not "What can I do to get my child to stop XYZ or start XYZ," but rather, "How can I be with my child and show them that I love them unconditionally, and have the skills necessary to understand what is happening within their young brains and bodies?"

Mona Delahooke, author of *Beyond Behaviors*, eloquently explains that there are three core mistakes of the "status quo" parenting, which focuses solely on behavior as the root, rather than the symptom of a more systemic imbalance.

She writes that firstly, as parents, we are trained to address the superficial problem rather than the source of the problem.



Example 1:

Power Over/Under behavioral approach: “Stop that whining right now or you’re getting a time out **or** you’re going to lose car privileges this weekend!” or, “Oh my goodness, why do you whine SO MUCH? Just get what you want and stop making that noise!”

Power with, beneath behaviors approach: “Hey, are you feeling stressed? Let’s move outside where there are not so many people” or, “Hey, I hear you, and I wonder if we need some fresh air before we continue our negotiation? I can tell that this conversation is stressful for you,” or, “Hey, we’ve got this (parent holds out hands for a hug).”

We fail to correctly interpret behavior as an unconscious expression of stress in the child or simply, where they are at developmentally; we mistakenly view it as *intentional* misbehavior. We expect children to change their behaviors with internal motivation that comes from synchronizing their thoughts and emotions, when their brains have not yet developed these functions!

Example 2:

Power Over/Under and behavioral approach: “If you stay calm and do not run around the store while I’m shopping, mommy will be so proud of you, and you will get to have ice cream after your dinner tonight!” or the parent ignores the child and walks away from them while shopping, they cannot deal with the moment.

Power with, beneath behaviors approach: “This store may be a little busy tonight sweetie, so I am going to help you stay close to me. You can ride in the cart and be a supermarket hero, or you can ride in the carrier on my back in case you need snuggles.” (If the child struggles at the store, the parent can see they are overstimulated from the amount of lights, sounds, and activity. The parent would offer physical contact to see the child’s sensory system. No punishment or reward needed.)

Secondly, Mona shares that most parents have been trained to use a one-size-fits-all approach instead of tailoring the strategies to fit the individual child.

We take in generic parenting advice and behavioral techniques without considering the unique needs of the parent, the child, and the relationship between parent and child. We sometimes lack the attunement to self and intuition, and sometimes lack the clarity of truly knowing what our specific child needs. This can create more confusion and stress.



Power Over/Under behavioral approach: A parent of three children had a fourth child. Her first three kids felt excited by people and places and outings. The fourth child became overstimulated and felt stressed and concerned when around people and places they did not know.

The parent thinks this is not “normal” behavior because all the other kids liked to go out at that age! Instead of trying to learn that child’s specific needs to thrive and respect that child’s timeline of social engagement, the parent tries as many tricks and strategies as possible to get the fourth child to be social and outgoing like the rest of their children. (Note* There is nothing inherently “wrong” with finding ways to support children who struggle to socially engage. The difference is the intent and the consciousness: “I want my kid to socially engage because that’s what kids are supposed to do” versus “I’m curious how to support my child to access spaces of community joy, in their own way, at their own pace.”)

Power with, beneath behavior approach: I notice that my fourth child feels a bit more timid around social settings than my other three kids. I’m willing to get curious about what could be going on for my child, and what support, if any, I could offer? My goal is to connect with my child and as accurately as possible interpret their experience. My goal is not to make them different or change them. Rather than assuming that my child is suffering because of their feelings of timidity, or their desire to observe before engaging, I will ask my child if they would like my support? “I noticed that you watched your cousins playing at the park today, and you did not join in. Do you feel comfy watching the kids play? Do you wish you could play, too? Is anything stopping you? Would you like support from me to engage, or are you feeling fine with how things are?” (*Note, you would not ask these questions quickly or intensely, but slowly and without pressure in a low stimulation, high connection space.)

Thirdly, Mona shares that most parents connect with their children without an accurate developmental roadmap to ensure they are using the “right” parenting tools in congruence with their child’s development.

With the best of intentions, due to our collective lack of understanding of child development, we offer well-meaning strategies that misalign with what our children can execute.

Power Over/Under behaviorism approach: A parent sets up a “calm down corner” in their child’s bedroom. Whenever this child, who is three, hits their younger sibling, the parent brings the three-year-old to the “calm down corner” and leaves them alone to “think about how much hitting hurts other people.” The parent tells the child to come back when the child is “ready to play nicely.”



Yes, this strategy is inarguably more compassionate than a shout at the child and forceful removal to the "time out chair." However, a three-year-old, whose brain and nervous system cannot self-regulate through and complete a stress cycle of big frustration, is not benefited deep down by a well-meaning calm down corner. Yes, it may stop the hitting in the moment, yet the principle power imbalance remains: when you hit, I remove connection from you. When you hit, you will not be responded to by a caregiver who understands that you cannot control your impulsivity, and you cannot stop your hands from hitting each time frustration arises within you.

The irony is that the brain develops through a process of sequential milestones. This means that if developmental milestones are skipped (expecting a three-year-old to control their own impulses versus greeting the child with grounded warmth and a nourishing limit), then the brain doesn't just skip to the next level of competency! This is the 8- or 12-, or even 82-year-old who struggles with frustration as deeply as a three-year-old.

A power with, beneath behavior approach: The parent understands their three-year-old is still grappling with no longer being the center of the universe in the home. There is still grief here in the child, and some hurt and pain. When a baby takes the big sibling's toys and begins to chew on them, a level of frustration and stress arises in the child's brain that signals to the nervous system: THREAT! and the three-year-old experiences a natural physiological response to threat: ATTACK! Because the parent understands where the three-year-old is developmentally, they do not expect the three-year-old to control their "hitting hands" around the baby. Instead of setting up the three-year-old, the baby, and the parent for stress, the parent is on the floor with the kids, watching the three-year-old's stress cues, and intervening before the hitting happens. When this cannot happen, because—life!, then the parent would respond with something like:

"Oopsies, sweetie, come here." Making sure the baby is okay while also tending to three year old, the parent reassures, "Oof, it's hard when the baby takes your things. I'm here to help. Let's figure this out. I got you darlin'!"



XXVI. *What are your takeaways from the three “mistakes” above? Where in your parenting could you lean in and see beneath the surface more often?*

Thank you so much for your willingness, your courage, and your vulnerability. You are here to grow and expand. You are here for yourself, your child, children, and future. We are deeply appreciative of your work.



Summary

Takeaways:

- **10 Core Pillars of Transformational Parenting**

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| 1. Informed and Aware | 6. Loving Kindness and Forgiveness |
| 2. Intentional and Reflective | 7. Communication to Connect and Understand |
| 3. Present, Committed and Devoted to Imperfect Authenticity | 8. Nonviolence and Safety |
| 4. All Feelings Are Valid and Welcome | 9. Boundaries from Family Values |
| 5. Attuned and Empathetic | 10. Joy, Play and Fun |

- **Parenting Patterns**

- Power Over (authoritarian): A hierarchy where the parent dominates over the child and discounts the child's feelings, needs, thoughts, and voice.
- Power Under (permissive or uninvolved): A dynamic where the parent abandons their parental leadership or presence
- Power With: Relationship-driven, prioritizing safety, trust, equity, and curiosity

- **Parenting "Mistakes" (from *Beyond Behaviors*)**

- Addressing the superficial problem (behaviors) rather than the source.
- Using a single approach rather than tailor strategies to fit the individual child.
- Lacking an accurate child developmental roadmap.

Invitation to Practice:

- **Notice** when your current parenting style slips into (or rebels against) the pattern you experienced as a child.
- **Use curiosity** to view your parenting through the lens of possibility related to each pillar of transformational parenting.
- When you notice your parenting moving away from transformational parenting, **determine if a fear is present**, and soften it through compassion.
- **Renew your curiosity** of your child's development as they grow into a new phase.



References

1. Kohn, A. (2006). *Unconditional Parenting: Moving from Rewards and Punishments to Love and Reason*. Atria Books.
2. *Strict vs. Permissive Parenting* by Dr. Laura Markham, PhD. [View video here](https://www.kidsinthehouse.com/all-parents/parenting/parenting-styles/how-to-be-a-strict-and-permissive-parent) or visit: <https://www.kidsinthehouse.com/all-parents/parenting/parenting-styles/how-to-be-a-strict-and-permissive-parent>
3. *4 Types of Parenting Styles and Their Effects on the Brain* by Pamela Li. [Read the article here](http://www.parentingforbrain.com/4-baumrind-parenting-styles/) or visit: <http://www.parentingforbrain.com/4-baumrind-parenting-styles/> (Note: This article is based on research from the 1960s. The intention is to illustrate the impact of various “traditional” parenting styles as you engage in supportive conversations with your clients. The latest research promotes conscious and transformational parenting, which had not yet been developed at the time of Baumrind’s research.)
4. Baumrind, D. (1966). *Effects of authoritative parental control on child behavior*. *Child Development*, 37 (4), 891.
5. Chen, Iris. (2021). *Untigerizing: Peaceful Parenting for the Deconstructing Tiger Parent*. Introduction.

